on the verge of an existential crisis. If the 'meltdown' does happen, the AIADMK core voter base will be ripe for the picking by the BJP. Annamalai, with his swarthy good looks, oratorical skills and reputation for being a *singham* (lion) when he was a police officer, has become the sword arm of that plan.

Hailing from a farming family in Karur district, some 130 km from Coimbatore, he belongs to the influential Gounder community. Annamalai secured an engineering degree from a well-known Coimbatore college before getting an MBA from IIM Lucknow. Both these qualifications show up in his meticulous approach to political issues, studying them in-depth before articulating his views. These come with a disarming frankness that frequently draws flak from critics, who have dubbed him "a loose cannon". He has also exhibited a willingness to take on dares—a quality he apparently cultivated as a police officer in Karnataka, where he served for eight years (2011-19). After he left the force, he briefly set up an NGO that worked on grassroots environmental change before deciding to join the BJP because it could help "execute the development agenda" he wanted.

There is little doubt, though, that it is Annamalai's ability to generate controversy (his opponents call it "noise") and draw attention that has catapulted him centre stage. He is now even perceived as a threat to the AIADMK leadership headed by the former chief minister Edappadi Palaniswami (EPS) who, incidentally, also belongs to the Gounder caste. Last year, Annamalai set out on a gruelling statewide yatra called '*En Mann, En Makkal* (My land, my people)' that covered all 234 assembly constituencies and garnered plenty of traction. He was also responsible for the audio leaks that led to the state's popular finance minister Palanivel Thiaga Rajan (PTR) getting sidelined (the voice in the tape was making corruption allegations against the DMK top leadership). PTR denied it, but the damage was done.

More recently, in the thick of the election campaign, he produced an RTI document that revived the controversy over Katchatheevu, a tiny non-descript island lying between India and Sri Lanka. The charges were that the late prime minister Indira Gandhi had gifted it to Sri Lanka in 1974, and though it was detrimental to the state's interests, the then DMK government had gone along with the decision. That charge went off the rails when, instead of scoring points against the DMK, senior party leaders lashed out at Indira Gandhi. Soon, Annamalai's rivals put the Modi government on the mat for not moving the needle towards a solution in the past 10 years that it was in power. In damage control mode, the BJP leader now claims the Modi government has ensured that fewer Indian fishermen have been killed for violating the maritime boundary and also ensured speedier release of those arrested by the Sri Lankan coastguard.

The BJP's Tamil Nadu strategy is to push the vote percentage from the current four per cent to double digits and then push for the desired 20-25 per cent. This will enable the party to dethrone the AIADMK and become the prime challenger to the DMK. Annamalai knows it is an uphill task. The BJP is contesting in 19 constituencies on its own and has left 20 seats for the allies. The party had contested in only five constituencies in 2019. Asked about his chances, Annamalai, in between waving to supporters from his van, says, "This election, we are pulling out all the stops. We are expanding our party's reach and, yes, we are overstretched, with every BJP *karyakarta* doing double duty. But we are hoping to come out clear winners and achieve our ambition of reaching a 25 per cent vote share."

While rapid development and exposing the DMK's follies are the BJP's main planks, Annamalai sidesteps queries about his party's

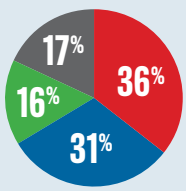


COIMBATORE

BUDDING LOTUS

LS 2009

- Winner **P.R. NATARAJAN** CPI(M)
- Runner-up **R. PRABHU** Congress
- 2nd runner-up **E.R. ESWARAN** KNMK*



For the 2009 election, CPI(M) was part of an alliance the included AIADMK, MDMK, PMK and the Left

*KNMK: Kongunadu Munnetra Kazhagam